

How long is “for ever”?

It seems like a silly question to ask at first but I assure you it is not. At first glance, we might think that the phrase “for ever” is the same as “eternity”; but, that’s not what the Bible teaches us.

Psalms 104:5

Who laid the foundations of **the earth**, that **it** should not be removed **for ever**.

Ecclesiastes 1:4

One generation passeth away, and another generation cometh: but **the earth** abideth **for ever**.

- “it” refers back to “the earth”.
- The earth abides “for ever”.
- But, what about the new heaven and the new earth in **Revelation 21:1**? If “for ever” was the same as eternity that would create a contradiction with these verses.

Matthew 24:35

Heaven and earth **shall pass away**, but my words shall not pass away.

Mark 13:31

Heaven and earth **shall pass away**: but my words shall not pass away.

- “*Shall pass away*” is a future tense event.
- “*pass away*” is both literal and figurative and it means exactly what we think it does (**Job 34:20**).
- So, what will happen to the current earth in the future?

Isaiah 51:6

Lift up your eyes to the heavens, and look upon the earth beneath: for **the heavens shall vanish away** like smoke, and **the earth shall wax old like a garment**, and they that dwell therein **shall die** in like manner: but my salvation shall be for ever, and my righteousness shall not be abolished.

- “*wax old like a garment*” is a figurative phrase.
 - The parallelism in **Psalms 102:26** teaches us that that phrase means “*perish*”.
- The phrase “*in like manner*” points back to both “*vanish away*” and “*wax old like a garment*” and teaches us that those phrases mean “to die/death”.

2 Peter 3:9-12

⁹ The Lord is not slack concerning his promise, as some men count slackness; but is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.

¹⁰ But the day of the Lord will come as a thief in the night; in the which **the heavens shall pass away** with a great noise, and **the elements shall melt** with fervent heat, **the earth also** and **the works** that are therein shall be burned up.

¹¹ Seeing then that **all these things** shall be dissolved, what manner of persons ought ye to be in all holy conversation and godliness,

¹² Looking for and hasting unto the coming of the day of God, wherein the heavens being on fire shall be dissolved, and the elements shall melt with fervent heat?

- What does “all these things” refer to?
 - The heavens (plural).
 - The elements.
 - The earth.
 - The works within the earth.

Psalms 102:24-27

²⁴ I said, O my God, take me not away in the midst of my days: thy years are throughout all generations.
²⁵ Of old hast thou laid **the foundation of the earth**: and **the heavens** are the work of thy hands.
²⁶ **They shall perish**, but thou shalt endure: yea, all of them shall **wax old like a garment**; as a vesture shalt thou change them, and they shall be changed:
²⁷ But thou art the same, and thy years shall have **no end**.

Hebrews 1:10-12

¹⁰ And, Thou, Lord, in the beginning hast laid **the foundation of the earth**; and **the heavens** are the works of thine hands:
¹¹ **They shall perish**; but thou remainest; and they all shall wax old as doth a garment;
¹² And as a vesture shalt thou fold them up, and they shall be changed: but thou art the same, and thy years shall not fail.

- The earth and the heavens will perish.

Since “*all these things*” shall be burned up/perish then “*for ever*” is now **necessarily** a finite period of **time**. This then paves the way for the new heaven and the new earth of **Revelation 21:1** and beyond (**Revelation 21:5** “*all*”).

Psalms 12:6-7

⁶ The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times.
⁷ Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation **for ever**.

- The written word (our physical Bible books) will be burned up with everything else on earth.
- And that’s precisely when God’s promise in **Psalms 21:7** ends.

Psalms 119:89

LAMED. **For ever**, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven.

- This is one of the very few (if not the only) verse that is not talking about the written word that we can see (**2 Corinthians 4:18**). But, the use of the phrase “*for ever*” is an important distinction.

Isaiah 40:8

The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand **for ever**.

1 Peter 1:23

Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth **for ever**.

1 Peter 1:25

But the word of the Lord endureth **for ever**. And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you.

- More references to the written word.

Matthew 24:35

Heaven and earth shall pass away, but **my words shall not pass away**.

Mark 13:31

Heaven and earth shall pass away: but **my words shall not pass away**.

- Is Jesus talking about the written word? The written word will pass away when the earth and all the works therein are burned up. Therefore, Jesus **is not** talking about the written word in these verses!

Remember how we read in [1 Peter 3:9-12](#) that the earth and **the works** therein will be burned up? Does that include our physical Bibles? Before you answer you might want to read this:

2 Corinthians 4:18

While we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen: for **the things which are seen are temporal**; but the things which are not seen are eternal.

- That includes our physical Bibles.
- God's **written** word has a prescribed shelf life.
 - And if we think very carefully it makes perfect sense. At some point in the near future God's **written** word will no longer exist.

So, now that we've firmly established that "*for ever*" is a finite period of **time** that begs the questions: when did it begin and when does it end? For the answer we go back to [Psalm 104:5](#) and [Ecclesiastes 1:4](#) because combined with what we've learned we can now deduce that the end of "for ever" is the same as the end of the current earth and is very likely the same as the end of time itself.

Genesis 1:1

In the **beginning** God created the heaven and the earth.

- Time begins (roughly: because of "in").

Revelation 21:1

And I saw a new heaven and **a new earth**: for the first heaven and **the first earth** were **passed away**; and there was no more sea.

- The end of "*for ever*" (the current earth) occurs before this.

Revelation 20:6-10

⁶ Blessed and holy is he that hath part in the first resurrection: on such the second death hath no power, but they shall be priests of God and of Christ, and shall reign with him a thousand years.

⁷ And when the thousand years are expired, Satan shall be loosed out of his prison,

⁸ And shall go out to deceive the nations which are in the four quarters of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them together to battle: the number of whom is as the sand of the sea.

⁹ And they went up on the breadth of **the earth**, and compassed the camp of the saints about, and the beloved city: and fire came down from God out of heaven, and devoured them.

¹⁰ And the devil that deceived them was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone, where the beast and the false prophet are, and shall be tormented day and night for ever and ever.

- The "last" events recorded on earth before the old earth passes away and the new earth is created.

Revelation 20:11

And I saw a great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face **the earth** and the heaven **fled away**; and there was found **no place for them**.

- The end of the current earth and heaven.

If you weren't already aware, the book of Revelation is "divided" into seven "parallel" sections, each beginning with the coming of Christ and ending with the eternal state. Colloquially this is referred to as "progressive parallelism" or "recapitulation". So for example, chapter 1 is roughly parallel to chapter 4.

Revelation	
Section	Chapters
1	1-3
2	4-7
3	8-11
4	12-14
5	15-16
6	17-19
7	20-22

Looking at it this way, we can see that **Revelation 10** is roughly parallel to **Revelation 21**. But, we know that **Revelation 10** occurs before **Revelation 21** chronologically because in **Revelation 10** the angel stands on the current earth.

So, why is that important?

Revelation 10:5-7

⁵ And the angel which I saw stand upon the sea and upon the earth lifted up his hand to heaven,

⁶ And swore by him that liveth for ever and ever, who created heaven, and the things that therein are, and the earth, and the things that therein are, and the sea, and the things which are therein, **that there should be time no longer:**

⁷ But in the days of the voice of the seventh angel, when he shall begin to sound, the mystery of God should be **finished**, as he hath declared to his servants the prophets.

- Because it's the end of time itself.
- **Till all be fulfilled** (**Matthew 5:18**, **24:34**, **Luke 21:32**).

When we combine all that we've learned the Bible teaches us that "*for ever*" is the same as "*until the end of time*".

Interestingly, the words "eternal/eternity" do not appear in the book of the Revelation. But, the concept does. The phrase "*for ever and ever*" appears 46 times in 46 verses in the Bible and the meaning of the phrase is self explanatory:

Exodus 15:18

The LORD shall **reign** for ever and ever.

1 Timothy 1:17

Now unto **the King** eternal, immortal, invisible, the only wise God, be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen.